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Bengal, Uttarakhand, Karnataka, Gujarat, Arunachal Pradesh, Andhra Pradesh and Tamil Nadu. These initiatives include the contracting and management of primary healthcare centres and affiliated sub-centres in remote, rural and tribal areas, and the free provision of high-quality drugs to the deprived segments of society and senior citizens.

Although these are all far-sighted measures, they are not enough. Three areas, in particular, could benefit from additional public-private partnerships.

First is the area of bolstering curriculums of and augmenting access to medical education in India. As affluence in the country increases, so will the onslaught of communicable and non-communicable diseases, most notable being ailments under the umbrella of metabolic disorders. India is already home to the largest diabetic population in the world. By 2015, the prevalence of diabetes is likely to grow from 2.8 per cent of the populace in 2005 to 3.7 per cent; and obesity from 1.3 to 2.7 per cent. And if India's 271 medical institutions continue to produce only about 31,000 graduates every year, the strain on the country's abysmal doctor-to-patient ratio will increase. Today, there is the equivalent of half-a-doctor per 1,000 people, a stark contrast to the 2.3 doctors per 1,000 in the world's advanced nations. However, India has the potential to build world-class medical colleges—if we bring together the private sector with its entrepreneurial and philanthropic commitment, practitioners and non-profits with their expertise, and the government machinery with its legitimising authority.

Second is the area of harnessing the organisational and technological capabilities of the

Unending plight:

Flood-affected patients being administered intravenous fluid lying on the floor in Raghupur Referral Hospital in Supaul district of north Bihar

Global Learning

INDIA COULD INTRODUCE PRIVATE PLAYERS IN PUBLIC HOSPITALS, LIKE PORTUGAL, WHICH ALREADY HAS 10 HOSPITALS UP FOR PRIVATE MAINTENANCE.

private sector to build a National Health Information Bureau. Such an organisation could use leapfrog technologies to facilitate the online aggregation of national and state-level health metrics, and economics across the country. Creating an autonomous entity that is sponsored by the government and that leverages the expertise of non-profit organisations and the private sector is essential to the success of an initiative of this nature. Such an online system could provide strategic input for decisions related to spend allocations, resources, and human capital and could be an effective mechanism to measure and monitor the performance and impact of several national programmes as well as state health departments. In the longer term, this institute could undertake systematic research and planning activities to help shape the future healthcare landscape.

Third is the area of exploring the feasibility of introducing private players to public hospitals in India. This bold step could learn from an initiative taken by Portugal's Ministry of Health a few years ago. As part of this programme, the Portuguese national health system has launched a public-private partnership to increase the supply of hospital services and to raise the level of clinical quality and service. With 10 hospitals taking part in the initial stages of the programme, the government is developing contracts with private firms to construct, maintain and operate those hospitals. The programme could have a significant impact, promoting a new health market that is more sophisticated and more competitive. This model may not be replicable in India, yet such approaches are worth exploring.

India's overall progress since Independence is noteworthy, yet not sufficient. If India is to rise to the level of other global leaders, it must inspire its private sector, civil society, government and non profits to work in unison to build its soft infrastructure, especially as about 320 million people are added to its population. Delivering high-quality, cost-effective healthcare will require a constant emphasis on preventive care and a holistic approach to wellness and to provide healthcare for India's growing population, all of the segments of our society—public and private, philanthropic and civic-minded—must organise systems that can deliver far-reaching improvements in the public-health system today.

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